

SIMPLY DELHI dance



VIRSAM SHARMA

by Shrimali in Delhi. "It's important for a dancer to have a good teacher who can introduce you to the dance form and teach you how to discover it," says Ivanova. Originally from the city of Volgograd (earlier Stalin-grad), her journey in Kathak began in Russia where she trained under an Indian teacher from Sanawar, Himachal Pradesh.

After learning for two years there, she took an ICCR scholarship and came to Delhi. That's when she saw Shrimali perform. "I was mesmerised by the dignified way in which she danced and just couldn't take my eyes off her," says Ivanova. It was then that she decided that Kathak was her life and she had to learn it under Shrimali. "I didn't know who Perna Shrimali was and if she taught dance, all I knew is that I had to dedicate my life to Kathak and learn under her." That's when she settled down in the capital and started training.

Ivanova's proudest moment was when she performed her first solo at India Habitat Centre in 2004. She has also choreographed fusion pieces which incorporated Oriental and Western dance forms.

But she maintains that India is where she finds the right audience for Kathak. "People abroad love the beauty of Kathak and its extravagance, but it's here that people really understand it," says Ivanova, who has plans to teach flamenco and other Western dance forms apart from Kathak, in Delhi.

Edith Humble from Sweden feels her country isn't too musical. "Even Western classical dance forms aren't encouraged there. Only street dance and folk forms are popular," says the 23-year-old, adding, "I learnt French ballet there since I was seven, but I had to eventually give it up because my body type does not suit the form."

While searching for other programmes four years ago, she read about Odissi. "The description sounded so beautiful that I applied for a scholarship here," says Humble who lives in the hostel of Shriram Bharatiya Kala Kendra and learns Chau dance there. She's convinced her love for Chau and Odissi will take her to south India one day.

Another expat passionate about India and its dance is French national Isabelle Anna. "My mother is a trained Kathakali dancer," says Anna, whose parents own Mandapa, the Indian culture centre for music and dance in France. But that's not where her Indian connection ends. Anna has an Indian sister as well, who was adopted when her mother was in India. "It's funny how I, being French decided to stay in India and how my sister has made France her home," says Anna, who lives in South Delhi.

Back in France, Anna discovered Kathak under Sharmila Sharma, who is a disciple of Pandit Birju Maharaj and used to take classes in Paris. Soon after, she applied for an ICCR scholarship, shifted base to India and began learning under Pandit Jai Krishan Maharaj, the eldest son of Pandit Birju Maharaj.

"Being a trained pianist, I appre-

What I love about classical forms is that they have set frames, and within that rigid frame you have to show your creativity. That is a challenge I enjoy.

EDITH HUMBLE,
Sweden